CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Part 6 - Governance, Network Security and Standards

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About This Report

This is an experimental, AI-driven research project from SRL. SRL is independent, with no outside funding and no sponsors. This tracker is a summarized pull of the public record, kept as a coherent, concise news update. It draws on the CA/Browser Forum's own ballots, mailing lists and published documents, and on the public sources of the browser root programs. An AI model reads those sources and writes the summary, and every statement links to the source it came from. Where two sources disagree, both are reported. AI makes mistakes, so check the linked source before relying on any statement. The tracker is updated each week that the public record shows a change.

This part covers the Forum's machinery rather than its certificate rules. The September edition listed these areas as configured but not yet researched, and they now carry enough record to report.

Section 1 covers the Network Security Working Group, whose one adopted ballot is in review and whose requirements drew two self-reports this week. Section 2 covers how the Forum governs itself, including the officers who take over on 1 December and a new member. Section 3 covers the IETF standards the guidelines cite, where the composite signature draft is one step from publication. Section 4 covers the audit regimes that check whether certificate authorities follow the rules.

1. Network Security Working Group

This group writes the Network and Certificate System Security Requirements, which govern how a certificate authority protects the systems that issue certificates rather than the certificates themselves.

Recent Developments

The group's restructuring ballot has passed after a long silence. NS-010 version 2 restructures the requirements sections, removes expired effective dates and updates a NIST reference [1]. Its vote ran from 10 August to 17 August 2026 [2]. No result followed, and on 9 September a participant asked on the list whether the chairs had forgotten to announce one [2].

The result was posted on 14 October [1]. The ballot passed with all sixteen voting certificate issuers and all three voting certificate consumers in favour, and no abstentions [1]. The consumers were Apple, Microsoft and Mozilla [1].

The ballot's text settles a question that earlier accounts left open. One account described an August ballot adding a section on infrastructure inventory, which seemed not to match NS-010's stated purpose. The draft shows they are the same ballot. NS-010 adds a new Section 1 for the certificate authority's infrastructure inventory and renumbers the sections after it [3].

The draft also replaces phased vulnerability management language, which expired on 15 April 2026, with a single requirement covering all certificate systems, support systems and network boundary controls [3]. Its NIST reference moves to Revision 4 of SP 800-63B [3].

The requirements were tested in public this week. On 23 October Sectigo filed two reports against itself under the current version [4]. One says an account review was not completed within three months, as Section 2.2.1.4 requires, and the other says an account was not removed from a retired VPN, as Section 3.2.3 requires [4]. Both were unconfirmed as of 25 October [4].

Current State

NS-010 version 2 is adopted and in its intellectual property review, which runs from 14 October to 13 November 2026 [5]. It cannot publish as a new version before that review ends. Its pull request in the group's repository remains open and unmerged, and the list has had no post since the review notice [3].

The published requirements are still version 2.0.5, from Ballot NS-008 in July 2025 [6]. The group's other draft, NS-009, would permit log storage systems in environments controlled by third parties [7]. It has not changed since May 2026 and has no ballot stage [7].

Unresolved Conflicts

The Forum's own ballots page still lists NS-010 version 2 as in its voting period [8]. The list posts show the vote closed in August and the result came in October [1]. The list is the record here, and the page lags it. An update to the page, or the ballot's publication in November, would close the gap.

2. Forum Governance

The Forum runs on bylaws, an intellectual property policy and elected officers, and changes to any of them move by Forum-level ballot or election rather than by working group.

Recent Developments

The Forum has chosen a new set of officers in two rounds. A special election for chairs ran from 14 September to 21 September and drew 21 ballots, with results posted on 23 September [9]. Dimitris Zacharopoulos was elected Forum chair, and three working group chairs were unopposed [9].

The network security chair race was tied between David Kluge and Aaron Poulsen [9]. On 24 September it was reported that the two candidates had agreed that Aaron Poulsen would take the chair [9].

The vice-chairs followed. Because no race was contested, the vice-chair ballot ran as a confirmation, from 6 October to 13 October, with no discussion period [10]. Nineteen ballots were received, and the results were posted on 15 October [10].

The confirmed vice-chairs are Karolina Ruszczynska of Certum for the Forum, and Tobias Josefowitz of Opera for the server certificate group [10]. Scott Rea of eMudhra takes S/MIME,

Dean Coclin of DigiCert code signing, David Kluge of Google network security, and Ben Wilson of Mozilla the definitions group [10].

A corrected slate of chairs was posted the same day [10]. Stephen Davidson of DigiCert takes the server certificate group and Rebecca Kelley of DigiCert the S/MIME group [10]. Martijn Katerbarg of Sectigo takes code signing, Aaron Poulsen of SSL.com network security, and Polina Glazyrina of Sectigo the definitions group [10].

The minutes of the September face-to-face meeting, published on 23 October, record a new member. Huawei's application to join as a certificate consumer was approved with no objections [11]. An unnamed probationary member satisfied the attendance requirement for voting status, and the Forum agreed to streamline how it reviews candidates, with a chart and standard questions to go on its wiki [11]. A further application, from GeeRoam Information Technology as an interested party, was on the server certificate group's agenda for 22 October, with no outcome yet posted [12].

A proposal for a new working group is also under discussion. A charter for a client authentication working group was discussed on the public list from 22 September to 24 September, with emerging consensus to proceed [13]. Its scope was clarified as mutual TLS for people, not email [13]. Part 4 covers the root program policy that moves client authentication out of server certificates.

Current State

All the new officers take office on 1 December 2026 [10]. DigiCert will hold two chairs and one vice-chair, and Sectigo two chairs [10]. Google, Mozilla and Opera each hold one vice-chair seat and no chair [10]. One incoming vice-chair, Scott Rea, is the eMudhra representative who announced on 25 October that his company is leaving public website certificates, as Part 4 records [14].

The intellectual property policy in force is version 1.4, effective since 1 June 2026 [15]. Ballot FORUM-037 adopted it, and it is the newest Forum-level ballot to pass [16]. No Forum-level ballot is in any stage now, and the client authentication charter has had no post since 24 September [16] [13].

Parts of the record are missing. The server certificate group's face-to-face minutes are now published, but the Forum plenary minutes from the same meeting and from the 8 October plenary are not [17] [11]. Huawei does not yet appear on the Forum's membership page [18].

One public question has drawn no answer. On 29 September a participant asked what "promptly" means in the subscriber obligations of the Baseline Requirements, given that the same document sets hard deadlines elsewhere [19]. No reply was visible by 25 October [19].

3. Referenced Standards

The guidelines cite IETF standards by number, so a draft becoming an RFC changes what a ballot can reference and when a requirement can be written.

Recent Developments

The composite signature draft is one step from publication. It defines how ML-DSA is paired with a conventional signature in one X.509 certificate, and the S/MIME group’s composite ballot depends on it, as Part 3 records. It reached final review at the RFC Production Center on 14 October, and on 19 October moved to a blocked state marked as awaiting final approval [20]. As of 25 October it had no RFC number [20].

Its companion for key encapsulation moved too. The IESG approved the composite key encapsulation draft on 12 October, and it entered the RFC Editor queue, where IANA acknowledged its registrations on 21 October [21]. The profile that applies composite key encapsulation to signed messages joined the queue on 15 October [22].

The TLS working group adopted a composite draft of its own. On 23 October it adopted a draft that brings composite ML-DSA signatures into the TLS handshake [23]. The two TLS drafts that put ML-KEM and ML-DSA directly into the protocol have waited for an editor since 12 October, after a hold whose reason the record does not give [24] [25].

The certificate request attestation draft is nearing approval. It reached its 32nd revision on 22 October, drew a yes ballot from its area director the same day, and goes before the steering group on 5 November [26]. New individual drafts in the same week cover seed-only ML-DSA and ML-KEM keys, composites with FN-DSA, an update to the timestamp protocol, and a revision of the enrollment protocol [22].

The ACME draft on account-bound domain labels went backward. Its area director began evaluation on 11 October and asked for a revised draft on 14 October [27]. No revision has been posted [27].

The Merkle Tree Certificates draft, the basis of the separate post-quantum trust path Chrome and Apple are designing, reached revision 07 on 7 October [28]. Chrome now requires new cosigner requests in its testing program to follow that revision [29].

Current State

No RFC on certificates, ACME, CAA or transparency appeared in October up to 25 October [30] [31]. RFC 5280, the core certificate profile, has had no erratum reported in 2026, and its newest is from September 2025 [32]. The CAA standards remain RFCs 8657, 8659 and 9495 [33].

The newest change to a standard the guidelines cite came before September. RFC 9919 defines a lightweight status protocol profile for high-volume environments and was published in July 2026 [34]. The ACME persistent DNS draft has stayed at revision 02 since 20 September [35].

4. Audit Regimes

A certificate authority proves compliance through an annual audit against WebTrust or ETSI criteria, and the root programs read those audits before granting or keeping trust.

Recent Developments

Two clusters of audit-related compliance bugs opened in mid-October, and both began to move this week. On 15 October D-Trust opened two bugs for findings in its 2026 ETSI audit, one on vulnerability management and one on the documentation of backup recovery tests [36]. Both were assigned on 21 October, and both cite the specific ETSI requirements they fell short of [4].

On 16 October one member of the public filed four bugs about late audit statements [37]. Each says an authority delivered its statement between 108 and 144 days after the period ended, without the required explanation [37]. The authorities named are ITI Brazil, MULTICERT, Consorci AOC and Entrust [37]. On 21 October CCADB staff asked Mozilla to review MULTICERT's records, while the other three bugs stayed unconfirmed [4]. Part 4 covers them with the rest of the incident record.

The Baseline Requirements set the yardstick. Audit reports must be public no later than three months after the audit period ends [38].

Current State

The audit standards themselves did not change. ETSI EN 319 411-1 remains at version 1.5.1 from April 2025, with no newer edition [39]. EN 319 401 remains at version 3.2.1 from January 2026, and EN 319 411-2 at version 2.6.1 from June 2025 [40] [41].

On the WebTrust side, the criteria page lists version 2.2.2 as the base criteria for certificate authorities [42]. The European conformity assessment bodies' council held its annual meeting in Tallinn on 17 September, and has posted nothing else in 2026 [43]. No root program changed its audit requirements between 2 October and 25 October [44].

Unresolved Conflicts

Two accounts disagree on the current WebTrust network security criteria. One says version 2.0.5 was released on 31 October 2025, effective for periods from 1 November 2025 and based on the Forum's requirements version 2.0.5 [45]. Later reads found version 1.7 still listed as current, effective for periods from April 2024 [46]. The criteria page itself refused a direct read again this week. A successful read of that page would settle it.

The WebTrust applicability matrix, updated on 1 August 2026, lists TLS baseline versions 2.2.5 and 2.10 [47]. Read as Forum version numbers, neither matches the published sequence. It is not clear from the record whether they are the Forum's numbers or WebTrust's own. A direct read of the matrix would settle it.

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